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Culture (OWC): [Shona \(FS05\)](#)

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Place Coverage: Zaka, Masvingo, Zimbabwe

Section Title(S): I. THE BOY'S AGE OF PUBERTY

Early in the morning, after the emission, the boy goes down to the river to wash. When he returns, he is not allowed to warm himself by the fire but must stay away from it, in the cold morning air. When he starts to shiver the men, who sit by the fire watching him, say: "The boy has warmed himself at the fire of the old woman (*chembere*)." What is the meaning of the boy's behaviour (which is prescribed by the elders)? Bathing and washing in "the pool of the river" (meaning quiet tributaries or bays) is meant to have the effect of "cooling down" what the boy has experienced in his dream. It is analogous to the "cooling down" of the husband who has satisfied his sexual desire in the pool (vagina) of his wife. The boy stays away from the fire so that all shall know what has happened to him during the night. The *jaya* and his newly awakened sexual desires must not become even more heated by the fire, the fire representing sexual intercourse as revealed by the saying "he has warmed himself at the old woman's fire". This also signifies that the boy has already had some sexual experience – "old woman" only means that the boy's first attempts were made with an experienced woman.

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Adolescent boys have hardly any sexual contact with girls. However, possible partners in intimate relationships (which may lead to sexual intercourse) are the *varamu* – those women with whom a man can have a joking relationship (cf below). By his shivering the boy betrays his "misdemeanour". Feelings of guilt after a lapse, and the belief in what will happen (i.e. that he will give himself away), are well-tryed psychological pitfalls to control the individual within the community. The Karanga's "natural" explanation, based on his "Weltbild", must also be considered: every man receives, before marriage, special kinds of medicine to protect him against the alien blood with which he will shortly come in contact and which can make him ill. But the *jaya* who sits there shivering with cold has not only already "been weakened by the fire", as

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one old man expressed it, he also lacks the protection against the alien blood because he has not yet taken any medicine.

Another typical ritual is confirmed by many Karanga elders: in the morning the boy tells his uncle of the happy event, and the uncle then tells  75 the boy's father. The father fetches the bow and arrows of his own dead father — the symbolic signs of the fertility of the lineage — and hands them to his son saying: "Here is your inheritance, look after it and guard it well." This ceremony represents the symbolic passing of the family's fertility from grandfather via father to son.

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